

Portfolio Readiness Assessment

Gate Protocol & Checklist · v1.0 · May 2026

1 · What This Artifact Is

The Portfolio Readiness Assessment is a focused gate that fires before any Portfolio Project begins — not at phase close and not at the end of all preceding projects. Its job is a single question with high stakes: is the accumulated skill, tooling familiarity, and PM depth sufficient to produce a public-facing deliverable that reflects well on thepmddev.com?

Portfolio Projects are stretch projects by design — comfortably doable within accumulated knowledge and skills to date, but demanding enough to require genuine effort and produce genuine proof. The Readiness Assessment confirms that the 'comfortably doable' threshold has been reached before the project begins. It does not wait for a perfect readiness state that never arrives.

This artifact is distinct from the Phase Retrospective (Artifact #25), which evaluates a completed phase. The Portfolio Readiness Assessment looks forward — at a specific upcoming Portfolio Project — and makes a binary call: Ready to proceed or Not yet ready with a defined remediation path.

2 · Trigger — When This Fires

Trigger event	Detail
The project immediately preceding a Portfolio Project closes its individual retro	The Portfolio Readiness Assessment fires before the Kickoff Protocol (Artifact #20) for the Portfolio Project. Sequence: preceding project retro closes → Readiness Assessment → Kickoff Protocol → Phase 1. The Kickoff Protocol does not run until the Readiness Assessment returns a Ready verdict.
A Portfolio Project is identified mid-phase during a project retro	If a project retro recommends adding a Portfolio Project to the phase list, the Readiness Assessment fires when that project reaches the front of the queue — not at the point of recommendation.
A previously Not Yet Ready verdict has been remediated	After remediation projects complete, the Readiness Assessment fires again for the same Portfolio Project. Prior assessment PDF is superseded and archived.

3 · Relationship to Phase Retrospective and Kickoff Protocol

Artifact	Trigger	Scope	Output
Individual Project Retro	Every project close	Single project evaluation	Project retro PDF. May flag phase extension or Portfolio Project addition.

Portfolio Readiness Assessment (this artifact)	Before every Portfolio Project begins	Targeted readiness gate for one specific upcoming Portfolio Project	Ready or Not Yet Ready verdict. Remediation path if not ready.
Kickoff Protocol — Artifact #20	After Readiness Assessment returns Ready	Project selection, North Star Document, deployment track lock	North Star Document. Kickoff Checklist.
Phase Retrospective — Artifact #25	Phase project list exhausted	Full phase evaluation — all projects, all competency goals	Phase Retro PDF. Locked forward decision.

4 · Five-Gate Assessment

The assessment runs five gates in sequence. Each gate returns a verdict. All five gates must return Ready for the Portfolio Project to proceed. A single Not Yet Ready gate triggers the remediation protocol in Section 5. The gates are ordered from most objective (Skills Tracker evidence) to most subjective (PM depth self-assessment), so that documented evidence anchors the conversation before self-assessment enters it.

Gate 1 · Skills Tracker Evidence — Artifact #21

Check	Pass condition	Fail condition
Are the prerequisite skills for this specific Portfolio Project at amber or green in the Skills Tracker?	Every skill explicitly required by the Portfolio Project's North Star Document scope is at amber (in progress) or green (complete). No required skill is gray.	One or more required skills remain gray. Identify which. These become the specific scope of any remediation project.
Are the primary tools required for this project familiar enough to use under project pressure — not just theoretically understood?	Tools used in at least one prior project within this phase. First-time tool introduction during a Portfolio Project is a risk, not a stretch.	A required tool has never been used in practice. Flag for remediation or scope adjustment before proceeding.

Gate 2 · PM Process Depth

A Portfolio Project runs all nine phases. Every phase output must be genuinely defensible — not a first attempt at that phase type.

Check	Pass condition	Fail condition
Has the user completed at least one prior full nine-phase cycle for a project of comparable or greater complexity?	Yes — P0 or any prior project that ran all nine phases to completion. The user knows what a complete cycle feels like and what each phase demands.	No comparable prior cycle exists. This is a structural gap — a Portfolio Project should not be the first time a phase type is encountered.

Are the artifact types required by this Portfolio Project — PRD, Persona, Roadmap, etc. — ones the user has produced and had coach-reviewed before?	Each required artifact type has been produced at least once in a prior project and received explicit coach feedback.	A required artifact type is being produced for the first time. Flag for a practice project before the Portfolio Project proceeds.
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Gate 3 · Confidence Score Floor

A Portfolio Project requires a minimum confidence floor — not because the project should be easy, but because a confidence score below the floor signals that foundational work is incomplete. Stretch projects are built on foundations, not in place of them.

Check	Pass condition	Fail condition
Is the current confidence score at or above the minimum floor for a Portfolio Project at this phase?	Score is at or above the phase-appropriate floor defined in the table below. Honest score, not aspirational.	Score is below the floor. A below-floor score before a Portfolio Project is a signal to pause, identify what is driving the low score, and address it.

Phase group	Minimum confidence floor	Rationale
Phase I (P1–P8 approx.)	1.5 / 10	Early phase. The floor is low because P0 started at 1.0 and growth is gradual. A score below 1.5 entering Phase I Portfolio work suggests P0 learnings have not transferred.
Phase II (P9–P16 approx.)	3.0 / 10	Target post-P1 is 4–5. A floor of 3.0 allows entry to Phase II Portfolio work before the full P1 target is reached, while ensuring meaningful growth from Phase I.
Phase III (P17–P24 approx.)	5.0 / 10	Approaching CPO peer review territory at P3. A score below 5.0 entering Phase III Portfolio work indicates Phase II competency goals were not fully achieved.
Phase IV+ (P25+)	6.5 / 10	Professional friction mode. Portfolio Projects at this phase are evaluated against professional PM standards. Score below 6.5 signals incomplete Phase III foundation.

Gate 4 · Evaluator Standard Check

Portfolio Projects appear on thepmdev.com and are reviewed by hiring evaluators. This gate asks the evaluator question explicitly before the project begins, not after it ships.

Check	Pass condition	Fail condition
Does this Portfolio Project solve a materially different evaluator-relevant problem from existing portfolio projects?	Yes — the project adds a new dimension of PM capability proof that does not already exist in the portfolio. Evaluators see range, not repetition.	The project duplicates a capability already demonstrated. Either the scope needs adjustment or a different Portfolio Project should be selected.

Is the project's intended output — the artifact, the deployed product, the case study — genuinely portfolio-quality when completed at the expected skill level?	The coach confirms that a successful completion of this project, at the user's current skill trajectory, would produce something an evaluator would find meaningful.	The project scope is either too narrow to demonstrate PM depth or too broad to be completable at current skill level. Scope adjustment required.
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Gate 5 · Honest Self-Assessment

The final gate is the most subjective — and therefore the most important to anchor carefully. The user's honest feeling about readiness is a real signal. Anxiety is not the same as unreadiness. But persistent, specific doubt about a particular skill or phase type is worth surfacing before the project begins.

Check	Pass condition	Fail condition
On an honest read — does this Portfolio Project feel like a stretch that is comfortably within reach, or does it feel genuinely out of reach?	Stretch within reach. The user identifies specific things that will be hard but cannot name a fundamental capability they are missing.	Genuinely out of reach. The user can name a specific capability, phase type, or tool that feels absent rather than just difficult. That specific gap is the remediation scope.
Is there anything about this specific project that triggers the known stall pattern — scope overwhelm, blank-page paralysis, perfectionism on a deliverable that doesn't need to be perfect yet?	No active stall triggers identified, or known triggers have a defined mitigation in the Kickoff Protocol's North Star Document.	An active stall trigger is present and unmitigated. Address it explicitly in the North Star Document before Phase 1 begins — do not proceed without it.

5 · Remediation Protocol — When Not Yet Ready

A Not Yet Ready verdict is not a failure. It is the assessment working correctly. The remediation path is always specific — it addresses the exact gate that failed, not a general 'do more work' instruction.

Gate that failed	Remediation scope	Re-assessment trigger
Gate 1 — Skills or tooling gap	One targeted learning project scoped specifically to develop the missing skill or introduce the missing tool in a lower-stakes context.	Readiness Assessment re-runs after learning project closes its individual retro.
Gate 2 — PM process depth	One additional full-cycle project of comparable artifact type added to the phase list before the Portfolio Project. Must include the specific artifact type that has not been produced before.	Readiness Assessment re-runs after practice project closes.

Gate 3 — Confidence score below floor	Investigate what is driving the low score before scoping remediation. Low score from a specific unresolved gap → targeted project. Low score from general anxiety without a specific gap → coach conversation before any project addition.	Readiness Assessment re-runs after confidence score reaches floor at close of next project.
Gate 4 — Evaluator standard not met	Scope adjustment to the Portfolio Project itself before any new projects are added. Most Gate 4 failures are scope problems, not readiness problems.	Readiness Assessment re-runs with revised project scope. No additional projects required in most cases.
Gate 5 — Stall trigger unmitigated	Coach and user work the stall trigger explicitly — identify it, name it, build its mitigation into the North Star Document before Phase 1. No new project required. This is a coaching conversation, not a gap project.	Readiness Assessment Gate 5 re-evaluated after North Star Document includes explicit stall mitigation.

6 · Output Format — What Gets Produced

Output	Format	Contents	Filed to
Readiness Assessment PDF	PDF	Five gate verdicts with supporting evidence. Overall verdict: Ready or Not Yet Ready. If Not Yet Ready: specific gate that failed and remediation path.	docs/current/ — versioned filename
Decision Log entry — if Not Yet Ready	PMD_DECISION_LOG.md	Remediation decision with gate identified, scope defined, and cross-reference to this assessment PDF by filename.	Repo root — appended to ROAD section
Kickoff Protocol trigger	Artifact #20	If verdict is Ready: Kickoff Protocol fires immediately. Readiness Assessment PDF is attached as supporting context.	Live session

7 · Locked Decisions

Decision	Detail
Fires before Kickoff Protocol, not before Phase 1	The Kickoff Protocol does not run until the Readiness Assessment returns Ready. Sequence is fixed: Readiness Assessment → Kickoff Protocol → Phase 1.
All five gates must pass	One Not Yet Ready gate blocks the Portfolio Project regardless of how strong the other four gates are. No averaging. No overrides.

Portfolio Projects sit inside phases	Approximately two-thirds through the phase — enough preceding projects to make it achievable, enough runway after it to address what it surfaces. Not the last project in a phase. Not after phase close.
Stretch within reach — not perfect readiness	The assessment does not look for a perfect readiness state. It looks for 'comfortably doable within accumulated knowledge and skills.' Waiting for perfect readiness is the stall mechanism in gate form.
Remediation is always specific	Every Not Yet Ready verdict names the exact gate, the exact gap, and the exact remediation scope. 'Do more work' is not a remediation path.
Decision Log records Not Yet Ready outcomes	Ready verdicts proceed directly to Kickoff Protocol — no Decision Log entry needed. Not Yet Ready verdicts are system-level events that affect roadmap sequencing and belong in the Decision Log.
P() helper — all table cells	Per locked PDF pattern. All table cell content wrapped in Paragraph. VALIGN TOP. Never plain strings.

Version History

Version	Key change	Date
v1.0	Initial spec — trigger definition, relationship to Phase Retro and Kickoff Protocol, five-gate assessment (Skills Tracker evidence, PM process depth, confidence score floor with phase-appropriate thresholds, evaluator standard check, honest self-assessment), remediation protocol per gate, output format, Decision Log integration.	May 2026